

Annual Town Report  
Blandford, Massachusetts  
2025-2026



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Town Hall Telephone: 413-848-4279

## REPRESENTATIVES IN UNITED STATES CONGRESS

### U.S. Senators

**Ed Markey** 1550 Main Street, 4th Floor  
975 JFK Federal Building Springfield, MA 01103  
15 New Sudbury Street 413-785-4610  
Boston, MA 02203  
617-565-8519

255 Dirksen Senate Office Building  
Washington, DC 20510S  
Phone: 202-224-2742

**Elizabeth Warren** 1550 Main Street, Suite 406  
2400 JFK Federal Building, Springfield, MA 01103  
15 New Sudbury Street 413-788-2690  
Boston, MA 02203  
617-565-3170

311 Hart Senate Office Building  
Washington, DC 20510  
Phone: (202) 224-4543

### U.S. Congressman Richard E. Neal

Washington Office 300 State Street, Suite 200  
Springfield, MA 01105  
372 Cannon House Office Building 413-785-0325  
Washington, DC 20515 Fax: 413-747-0604  
Tel: 202-225-5601  
Fax: 202-225-8112  
Pittsfield Office  
78 Center St.  
Pittsfield, MA 01201  
Tel: 413-442-0946 Fax: 413-443-2792

## HAMPDEN COUNTY DISTRICT ATTORNEY

**District Attorney Anthony Gulluni**  
Hampden County District Attorney  
Superior Court & District Court  
50 State Street  
Springfield, MA 01102  
Superior Court Telephone: 413-747-1000  
Superior Court Fax: 413-781-4745  
District Court Telephone: 413-747-1001  
District Court Fax: 413-747-5628

## **GOVERNMENTAL DISTRICTS – STATE**

### **Governor's Office**

Maura Healey, Governor  
Kim Driscoll, Lt. Governor  
Boston Office  
Massachusetts State House, 24 Beacon St.  
Office of the Governor, Room 280  
Boston, MA 02133  
Tel: 617-725-4000 Fax: 413-784-1203

Springfield Office  
436 Dwight Street, 3rd floor  
Springfield 01103  
Tel: 413-784-1200

### **Secretary of the Commonwealth**

William Francis Galvin  
Boston Office  
State House, Room 337  
Boston, MA 02133  
Tel: (617) 727-7030  
Fax: 617-742-4528  
Toll free: 1-800-392-6090  
cathy.molta@sec.state.ma.us  
Email: cis@sec.state.ma.us

Springfield Office  
436 Dwight Street, Room 102  
Springfield 01103  
Tel: 413-784-1376  
Fax: 413-784-1379

### **Representatives in Massachusetts General Court**

Representative: Nicholas Boldyga (R) 3rd Hampden District

State House Address  
Room 167  
State House  
Boston, MA 02133  
Email: Nicholas.Boldyga@mahouse.gov

District Office (preferred mailing address)  
P.O. Box 1495  
Southwick, MA 01077  
Tel: 413-274-8084

Senator: Paul Mark (D) Berkshire, Hampshire, Franklin and Hampden  
State House  
Room 504  
Boston, MA 02133  
Tel: 617-722-1625

773 Tyler Street  
Pittsfield, MA 01201  
Tel: 413-464-5635

Please see the state's website for more information: [www.mass.gov](http://www.mass.gov)

|                               |
|-------------------------------|
| <b>ELECTED TOWN OFFICIALS</b> |
|-------------------------------|

Title, Term Expires

**Assessor (3 years)**

David Hopson 2025

Michaela Smith appointed

Steve Jemiolo 2026

**Cemetery Commission (3 years)**

TJ Cousineau 2025

Stephen Jemiolo 2027

Peter Sparks 2026

**Fence Viewer (3 years)**

VACANT

**Fence Viewer (2 years)**

VACANT

**Field Driver (3 years)**

VACANT

**Health, Board of (3 years)**

Jennifer Girard 2025

Brett Hartley 2027

Pat Lombardo 2026

**Library Trustee (3 years)**

Amy Hagstrom, appointed to 2028

Byam Stevens 2026

Mary Kronholm 2027

**Moderator (3 years)**

David Hopson 2027

**Municipal Light Plant Board (3 years)**

Kim Bergland 2027

Peter Langmore 2026

June Masse 2025

Title, Term Expires

**Planning Board (5 years)**

Edna Wilander 2029

Sarah Simpson 2028

Paul Martin 2029

Greg Garfield 2028

Bob Twyman, Associate Member 2028

**School Committee (3 years)**

Keri Morawiec 2027

Nicole Daviau 2026

**Select Board (3 years)**

Jackie Coury 2028

Cara Letendre 2026

Theodore Cousineau 2027

**Town Clerk (3 years)**

Doris Jemiolo 2026

**Tree Warden (3 years)**

Mark Boomsma 2027

**Water Commissioner (3 years)**

Brad Curry 2027

Peter Thayer 2025

Vacant – one seat

If you have any interest in being appointed to fill one of the vacancies on any of the boards, you are encouraged to attend their meeting(s), speak with their board members, and submit a letter of interest to both the board of your interest and the Board of Selectmen

|                                                                                               |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Please see the town website for the most up-to-date information on appointed officials</b> |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|

## Select Board Report

The Select Board is pleased to submit the following report outlining the accomplishments, ongoing efforts, and major initiatives undertaken during the 2024–2025 fiscal year. This year has been one of significant progress, collaboration, and thoughtful planning across multiple departments and community priorities.

### Community Development and Housing Support

The Board successfully concluded the Community Development Block Grant Program in partnership with the Pioneer Valley Planning Commission (PVPC). Through this program, seven Blandford homes received much-needed rehabilitation support—an important investment in maintaining safe, accessible housing for our residents.

### Staffing and Departmental Leadership

This year brought several key personnel changes essential to town operations:

- **Kelli Pontbriand** was hired as the Town Accountant.
- A full search was completed for a new **Highway Superintendent**, resulting in the hiring of **Ray Hultay**.
- The Board also oversaw the hiring of several additional Highway Department employees to strengthen the department's capacity.
- With Select Board oversight, the Water Department conducted a search for administrative support, resulting in the hiring of **Jasmine Ortega** as Administrative Assistant.
- A search committee for a full-time Water Superintendent was created, and an interim superintendent was appointed while the process continues.

### Public Safety and Emergency Services

The Select Board worked closely with Springfield Water and Sewer and the Blandford Fire Department to establish an intergovernmental agreement and accept the donation of a new brush truck—an important enhancement to the Fire Department's equipment and emergency readiness.

The Board also continued efforts to identify a viable location for a future Fire Department facility. After careful review, the Town Hall site was determined not feasible, and alternative locations remain under consideration.

### Training, Safety, and Risk Reduction

The Board collaborated with **Jennifer Girard** to coordinate safety trainings for the Highway Department. These trainings aim to enhance workplace safety practices while ultimately reducing costs associated with the town's annual insurance contract.

### Library Expansion Efforts

Throughout the year, the Board supported the Library Trustees and Library Director in their ongoing work with the Massachusetts Board of Library Commissioners (MBLC) grant process for the proposed library expansion. This project continues to represent an exciting opportunity for expanded resources and community space.

### Professional Development

The Board encouraged and supported **Cristina Ferrera** in completing the Inspector General's procurement training, further strengthening the town's internal capacity for compliant and efficient purchasing practices.

### Battery Energy Storage System (BESS) Review

In March, the Board was informed of a proposed Battery Energy Storage System (BESS) project on North Blandford Road. In response, the Board organized multi-board and committee meetings in April and again in May to review the site location, megawatt capacity, and required permitting.

Under Board oversight, Ms. Ferrera contacted Senator Mark's office and NSTAR to raise concerns regarding safety and regulatory oversight. Following these discussions, in May the Board formally approved a resolution opposing the siting of utility-scale BESS facilities in Blandford.

#### **Community Engagement and Inter-Department Coordination**

To strengthen communication and coordination across town departments, the Board initiated monthly round-table meetings. These sessions have provided a valuable forum for updates, problem-solving, and collaborative planning.

#### **Historic Preservation**

The Select Board approved the placement of a new historic marker commemorating **Jethro Jones**, to be installed at the corner of Blair Road and Jethro Jones Road. This marker preserves and highlights a meaningful piece of Blandford's history for future generations.

#### **Conclusion**

The Select Board extends its gratitude to all town employees, committee members, and volunteers whose dedication and collaboration made this year's progress possible. We remain committed to transparent governance, responsible stewardship, and continued service to the residents of Blandford.

Respectfully submitted,  
The Blandford Select Board

## TOWN ADMINISTRATOR

Fiscal Year 2026 was a defining year for Blandford; marked by challenge, resilience, and meaningful progress. Throughout the year, considerable effort was dedicated not only to addressing immediate operational needs, but also to identifying long-term priorities and building a stronger foundation for the future. While municipal government is often measured in budgets, projects, and regulations, this year served as a reminder that the true strength of Blandford lies in its people.

One of the most significant challenges faced this year was the unprecedented influx of commercial solar and Battery Energy Storage System. These projects raised substantial concerns regarding public safety, environmental impacts, infrastructure, emergency response capabilities, and preservation of Blandford's rural character and natural resources. In response, Town boards, committees, volunteers, and residents devoted countless hours to reviewing complex information, participating in public discussions, and navigating an increasingly technical regulatory process.

I would like to personally thank the EPSEC Committee, Planning Board, Conservation Commission, and Select Board for their tireless work, professionalism, and dedication throughout this process. I would also like to recognize the residents of Blandford, whose engagement and participation demonstrated the pride, resilience, and commitment that continue to define this community.

Even under difficult circumstances, Blandford came together in a way that reflects the very best of small-town government and community involvement, and it is my hope that momentum continues as we move into Fiscal Year 2027.

Fiscal Year 2026 also brought meaningful progress in addressing several longstanding operational and staffing needs. The Town was able to fully staff the Highway Department, provide additional administrative support within the Assessor's Office, and welcome a full-time Assistant in the Treasurer/Collector's Office. While these may appear to be small changes, they represent important investments in efficiency, continuity, and the long-term stability of Town operations.

At the same time, the Town continued moving forward on several key priorities for the community, including preventative maintenance of Town-owned properties, the Water Department SCADA project, upgrades to audio and visual equipment to improve public meetings, and continued progress on the library expansion project. Blandford also continued working toward a now nearly fully funded Other Post Employment Benefits account, which remains critical to the Town's long-term financial stability and bond rating. In addition, the Town anticipates dedicating renewed focus and collaboration toward evaluating the future direction of the Fire Department building project to ensure the long-term needs of the community continue to be thoughtfully and responsibly considered.

As a rural community of approximately 1,200 residents, Blandford faces many challenges that often go unseen by those unfamiliar with municipal government. Despite limited staffing and a small tax base, the Town is still responsible for meeting the same legal, administrative, financial, and operational obligations as every other municipality in Massachusetts. Much of this work is accomplished through the dedication of employees, elected officials, volunteers, and residents who consistently step forward because they care deeply about the Town and its future.

That willingness to work together is what continues to make Blandford special. It is reflected in the volunteer board and committee members who dedicate countless hours of service

leaving personal opinions aside to do what is in the best interest of the Town, the employees who consistently go above and beyond, and the residents who continue to support projects, events, and initiatives that strengthen the fabric of the community.

Blandford possesses something no budget can buy: a genuine sense of community. It is my sincere hope that moving forward we continue to strengthen that sense of community by recognizing that supporting Blandford means more than identifying challenges; it means contributing time, effort, ideas, and cooperation toward meaningful solutions that move the Town forward for the benefit of all.

Finally, I would like to personally thank Executive Assistant Joann Martin, whose hard work, professionalism, and unwavering dedication are invaluable to the Town each and every day. I would also like to thank Select Board members Jackie Coury, Cara Letendre, and TJ Cousineau for their steadfast commitment to Blandford, their collaborative leadership, and their continued support throughout the year. Together, their dedication and service continue to help guide Blandford toward a promising Fiscal Year 2027.

Cristina C. Ferrera  
Town Administrator

**TOWN OF BLANDFORD**  
**COMBINED BALANCE SHEET**  
June 30, 2025

|                                           | Governmental Fund Types |                    |                     |              | Proprietary<br>Fund Types | Fiduciary<br>Fund Types | Account<br>Groups   |                   |
|-------------------------------------------|-------------------------|--------------------|---------------------|--------------|---------------------------|-------------------------|---------------------|-------------------|
|                                           | General                 | Special<br>Revenue | Capital<br>Projects | Enterprise   |                           |                         | Trust and<br>Agency | Long-term<br>Debt |
|                                           |                         |                    |                     |              |                           |                         |                     |                   |
| <b>ASSETS</b>                             |                         |                    |                     |              |                           |                         |                     |                   |
| Cash and cash equivalents                 | 1,587,923.31            | 373,020.31         | 10,717.77           | 963,569.60   | 3,086,759.75              |                         |                     | 6,021,990.74      |
| Receivables:                              |                         |                    |                     |              |                           |                         |                     |                   |
| Personal property taxes                   | 9,930.98                |                    |                     |              |                           |                         |                     | 9,930.98          |
| Real estate taxes                         | 284,246.71              |                    |                     |              |                           |                         |                     | 284,246.71        |
| Allowance for abatements and exemptions   | (50,005.41)             |                    |                     |              |                           |                         |                     | (50,005.41)       |
| Tax liens                                 | 473,927.07              |                    |                     | 33,094.26    |                           |                         |                     | 507,021.33        |
| Motor vehicle excise                      | 28,039.38               |                    |                     | 129,079.42   |                           |                         |                     | 28,039.38         |
| User fees                                 |                         |                    |                     | 19,967.37    |                           |                         |                     | 129,079.42        |
| Utility liens added to taxes              |                         |                    |                     |              |                           |                         |                     | 19,967.37         |
| Other receivables                         | 214,381.48              |                    |                     |              |                           |                         |                     | 214,381.48        |
| Foreclosures/Possessions                  | 70,789.69               |                    |                     |              |                           |                         |                     | 70,789.69         |
| Amounts to be provided - payment of bonds |                         |                    |                     |              |                           |                         |                     |                   |
| Total Assets                              | 2,619,233.21            | 373,020.31         | 10,717.77           | 1,145,710.65 | 3,086,759.75              | 2,845,483.80            |                     | 2,845,483.80      |
|                                           |                         |                    |                     |              |                           |                         |                     | 10,080,925.49     |
| <b>LIABILITIES AND FUND EQUITY</b>        |                         |                    |                     |              |                           |                         |                     |                   |
| Liabilities:                              |                         |                    |                     |              |                           |                         |                     |                   |
| Withholdings                              | (4,379.11)              |                    |                     |              |                           |                         |                     | (4,379.11)        |
| Other liabilities                         | (2,500.00)              |                    |                     |              |                           |                         |                     | (2,500.00)        |
| Deferred revenue:                         |                         |                    |                     |              |                           |                         |                     |                   |
| Real and personal property taxes          | 244,172.28              |                    |                     |              |                           |                         |                     | 244,172.28        |
| Tax liens                                 | 473,927.07              |                    |                     | 33,094.26    |                           |                         |                     | 507,021.33        |
| Foreclosures/Possessions                  | 70,789.69               |                    |                     |              |                           |                         |                     | 70,789.69         |
| Motor vehicle excise                      | 28,039.38               |                    |                     |              |                           |                         |                     | 28,039.38         |
| User fees                                 |                         |                    |                     | 129,079.42   |                           |                         |                     | 129,079.42        |
| Utility liens added to taxes              |                         |                    |                     | 19,967.37    |                           |                         |                     | 19,967.37         |
| Other receivables                         | 214,381.48              |                    |                     |              |                           |                         |                     | 214,381.48        |
| Tailings                                  | 5,243.37                |                    |                     |              |                           |                         |                     | 5,243.37          |
| Agency Funds                              |                         |                    |                     |              | 21,091.41                 |                         |                     | 21,091.41         |
| Notes payable                             |                         |                    | 1,090,000.00        |              |                           |                         |                     | 1,090,000.00      |
| Bonds payable                             |                         |                    |                     |              |                           | 2,845,483.80            |                     | 2,845,483.80      |
| Total Liabilities                         | 1,029,674.16            | 0.00               | 1,090,000.00        | 182,141.05   | 21,091.41                 | 2,845,483.80            |                     | 5,168,390.42      |
|                                           |                         |                    |                     |              |                           |                         |                     |                   |
| Fund Equity:                              |                         |                    |                     |              |                           |                         |                     |                   |
| Reserved for encumbrances                 | 40,000.00               |                    |                     | 20,000.00    |                           |                         |                     | 60,000.00         |
| Reserved for expenditures                 | 40,176.00               |                    |                     | 136,375.00   |                           |                         |                     | 176,551.00        |
| Reserved for continuing appropriations    | 394,499.39              |                    |                     |              |                           |                         |                     | 394,499.39        |
| Reserved for appropriation deficit        | (12,347.74)             |                    |                     |              |                           |                         |                     | (12,347.74)       |
| Reserved for snow and ice deficit         | (68,023.98)             |                    | (1,079,282.23)      |              |                           |                         |                     | (68,023.98)       |
| Undesignated fund balance                 | 1,195,255.38            | 373,020.31         |                     | 807,194.60   | 3,065,668.34              |                         |                     | 3,554,661.80      |
| Unreserved retained earnings              |                         | 373,020.31         | (1,079,282.23)      | 963,569.60   | 3,065,668.34              | 0.00                    |                     | 807,194.60        |
| Total Fund Equity                         | 1,589,559.05            | 373,020.31         | (1,079,282.23)      | 963,569.60   | 3,065,668.34              |                         |                     | 4,912,535.07      |
|                                           |                         |                    |                     |              |                           |                         |                     |                   |
| Total Liabilities and Fund Equity         | 2,619,233.21            | 373,020.31         | 10,717.77           | 1,145,710.65 | 3,086,759.75              | 2,845,483.80            |                     | 10,080,925.49     |

|                               | <u>Final<br/>Budget</u> | <u>Expenses</u> | <u>Carried Forward<br/>Fiscal 2026</u> | <u>Closed<br/>Surplus</u> |
|-------------------------------|-------------------------|-----------------|----------------------------------------|---------------------------|
| <b>Moderator</b>              |                         |                 |                                        |                           |
| Stipend                       | \$ 500.00               | \$ 500.00       |                                        | \$ -                      |
| <b>Select Board</b>           |                         |                 |                                        |                           |
| Salary                        | \$ 22,431.55            | \$ 24,947.00    |                                        | \$ (2,515.45)             |
| Elected Stipend               | \$ 8,000.00             | \$ 7,471.15     |                                        | \$ 528.85                 |
| Expense                       | \$ 4,500.00             | \$ 5,743.53     |                                        | \$ (1,243.53)             |
| <b>Town Administrator</b>     |                         |                 |                                        |                           |
| Salary                        | \$ 85,000.00            | \$ 80,938.67    |                                        | \$ 4,061.33               |
| <b>Finance Committee</b>      |                         |                 |                                        |                           |
| Expenses                      | \$ 200.00               | \$ 146.00       |                                        | \$ 54.00                  |
| Reserve Fund                  | \$ 31,960.00            | \$ -            |                                        | \$ 31,960.00              |
| <b>Town Accountant</b>        |                         |                 |                                        |                           |
| Accounting Service            | \$ 49,000.00            | \$ 48,050.00    |                                        | \$ 950.00                 |
| Audit Expense                 | \$ 21,000.00            | \$ 20,000.00    |                                        | \$ 1,000.00               |
| <b>Board of Assessors</b>     |                         |                 |                                        |                           |
| Elected Salary                | \$ 5,000.00             | \$ 5,000.00     |                                        | \$ -                      |
| Assistant Salary              | \$ 10,256.00            | \$ 7,448.00     |                                        | \$ 2,808.00               |
| Registry of Deeds             | \$ 100.00               | \$ -            |                                        | \$ 100.00                 |
| Legal Notices                 | \$ 150.00               | \$ -            |                                        | \$ 150.00                 |
| Education & Training          | \$ 800.00               | \$ -            |                                        | \$ 800.00                 |
| Dues/Membership Fees          | \$ 250.00               | \$ 908.65       |                                        | \$ (658.65)               |
| RRG Services                  | \$ 67,000.00            | \$ 44,897.30    | \$ 3,150.00                            | \$ 18,952.70              |
| Expenses                      | \$ 3,100.00             | \$ 839.36       | \$ 487.50                              | \$ 1,773.14               |
| <b>Treasurer/Collector</b>    |                         |                 |                                        |                           |
| Salary Clerk 1                | \$ 15,480.00            | \$ 12,374.31    |                                        | \$ 3,105.69               |
| Salary Clerk 2                | \$ 15,480.00            | \$ 7,803.09     |                                        | \$ 7,676.91               |
| Contract Services             | \$ 96,000.00            | \$ 96,000.00    |                                        | \$ -                      |
| Expenses                      | \$ 10,000.00            | \$ 8,317.25     |                                        | \$ 1,682.75               |
| Tax Possession                | \$ 30,000.00            | \$ 1,630.50     |                                        | \$ 28,369.50              |
| <b>Town Council</b>           |                         |                 |                                        |                           |
| Expenses                      | \$ 25,000.00            | \$ 32,136.51    |                                        | \$ (7,136.51)             |
| <b>Information Technology</b> |                         |                 |                                        |                           |
| Expenses                      | \$ 84,000.00            | \$ 68,444.66    |                                        | \$ 15,555.34              |
| <b>Town Clerk</b>             |                         |                 |                                        |                           |
| Salary - Elected              | \$ 25,253.11            | \$ 25,253.11    |                                        | \$ -                      |
| Salary - Assistant            | \$ 3,529.44             | \$ 4,022.86     |                                        | \$ (493.42)               |
| Salary - Dog & Street Listing | \$ 791.00               | \$ 791.00       |                                        | \$ -                      |
| Salary - Vital Statistics     | \$ 51.00                | \$ 51.00        |                                        | \$ -                      |
| Dog & Street Listing Expense  | \$ 700.00               | \$ 210.83       |                                        | \$ 489.17                 |
| Expense                       | \$ 3,756.00             | \$ 3,439.76     | \$ 329.65                              | \$ (13.41)                |
| <b>Election</b>               |                         |                 |                                        |                           |
| Expense                       | \$ 7,336.00             | \$ 6,424.12     |                                        | \$ 911.88                 |
| <b>Registrars</b>             |                         |                 |                                        |                           |
| Salary                        | \$ 60.00                | \$ 60.00        |                                        | \$ -                      |
| <b>Conservation</b>           |                         |                 |                                        |                           |
| Stipend                       | \$ 8,000.00             | \$ 6,195.50     |                                        | \$ 1,804.50               |
| Agent Salary                  | \$ 10,732.80            | \$ 1,874.50     |                                        | \$ 8,858.30               |

|                                    |    |              |    |              |    |            |
|------------------------------------|----|--------------|----|--------------|----|------------|
| Expense                            | \$ | 1,000.00     | \$ | 1,156.22     | \$ | (156.22)   |
| <b>Planning</b>                    |    |              |    |              |    |            |
| Stipend                            | \$ | 8,000.00     | \$ | 8,000.00     | \$ | -          |
| Expense                            | \$ | 5,000.00     | \$ | 4,070.41     | \$ | 929.59     |
| <b>Zoning</b>                      |    |              |    |              |    |            |
| Stipend                            | \$ | 5,000.00     | \$ | 2,137.71     | \$ | 2,862.29   |
| Secretary Salary                   | \$ | 500.00       | \$ | -            | \$ | 500.00     |
| Expense                            | \$ | 500.00       | \$ | -            | \$ | 500.00     |
| <b>Building and Maintenance</b>    |    |              |    |              |    |            |
| Salary                             | \$ | 16,512.00    | \$ | 10,554.61    | \$ | 5,957.39   |
| Town Hall - Utilities              | \$ | 26,000.00    | \$ | 26,451.97    | \$ | 126.44     |
| Town Hall - Fuel                   | \$ | 20,000.00    | \$ | 22,339.62    | \$ | (2,339.62) |
| Town - Water Bills                 | \$ | 32,000.00    | \$ | 26,612.30    | \$ | 5,387.70   |
| Town Hall - Expenses               | \$ | 15,000.00    | \$ | 15,971.44    | \$ | (971.44)   |
| Town - Office Supplies             | \$ | 6,300.00     | \$ | 8,589.49     | \$ | 126.44     |
| New Town Hall - Maint & Repairs    | \$ | 24,000.00    | \$ | 23,026.51    | \$ | 1,972.08   |
| Old Town Hall - Expenses           | \$ | 6,950.00     | \$ | 7,963.06     | \$ | (1,013.06) |
| <b>Town Report</b>                 |    |              |    |              |    |            |
| Salary                             | \$ | 759.00       | \$ | 759.00       | \$ | -          |
| Expense                            | \$ | 710.00       | \$ | 491.17       | \$ | 218.83     |
| <b>Police Dept</b>                 |    |              |    |              |    |            |
| Expense                            | \$ | 98,912.00    | \$ | 99,272.00    | \$ | (360.00)   |
| <b>Fire Dept</b>                   |    |              |    |              |    |            |
| Stipend - Fire Chief               | \$ | 26,510.00    | \$ | 26,510.00    | \$ | -          |
| Expense                            | \$ | 56,865.00    | \$ | 26,628.86    | \$ | 474.90     |
| <b>Ambulance</b>                   |    |              |    |              |    |            |
| Hilltown Expense                   | \$ | 64,652.00    | \$ | 66,272.70    | \$ | (1,620.70) |
| <b>Building Inspector</b>          |    |              |    |              |    |            |
| Salary                             | \$ | 12,188.00    | \$ | 12,188.02    | \$ | (0.02)     |
| Expense                            | \$ | 500.00       | \$ | (60.00)      | \$ | 560.00     |
| <b>Animal Inspector</b>            |    |              |    |              |    |            |
| Salary                             | \$ | 1,500.00     | \$ | 1,289.84     | \$ | 210.16     |
| <b>Emergency Management</b>        |    |              |    |              |    |            |
| Expense                            | \$ | 100.00       | \$ | -            | \$ | 100.00     |
| <b>Animal Control</b>              |    |              |    |              |    |            |
| Salary                             | \$ | 4,000.00     | \$ | 4,000.00     | \$ | -          |
| Expense                            | \$ | 2,000.00     | \$ | 636.33       | \$ | 1,363.67   |
| <b>Tree Warden</b>                 |    |              |    |              |    |            |
| Stipend                            | \$ | 1,250.00     | \$ | 1,250.00     | \$ | -          |
| Outside Tree Work                  | \$ | 20,000.00    | \$ | 18,987.00    | \$ | 1,013.00   |
| Expense                            | \$ | 750.00       | \$ | -            | \$ | 750.00     |
| <b>Regional School Assessments</b> |    |              |    |              |    |            |
| Gateway Regional                   | \$ | 1,569,382.00 | \$ | 1,569,382.40 | \$ | (0.40)     |
| Westfield Tuition                  | \$ | 90,000.00    | \$ | 84,300.00    | \$ | 5,700.00   |
| Smith Tuition                      | \$ | 185,000.00   | \$ | 148,040.51   | \$ | 36,959.49  |
| Transportation                     | \$ | 31,878.00    | \$ | 30,950.00    | \$ | 928.00     |
| <b>Highway</b>                     |    |              |    |              |    |            |
| Salary                             | \$ | 289,747.75   | \$ | 269,636.35   | \$ | 300.00     |
| Overtime                           | \$ | 5,000.00     | \$ | 6,695.34     | \$ | (1,695.34) |

|                                         |               |               |                |
|-----------------------------------------|---------------|---------------|----------------|
| Clothing Allowance                      | \$ 4,000.00   | \$ 4,118.74   | \$ (118.74)    |
| Utilities                               | \$ 7,000.00   | \$ 4,306.74   | \$ 2,693.26    |
| Outside Equipment Repair                | \$ 51,940.00  | \$ 51,853.04  | \$ 86.96       |
| Vehicle Maint                           | \$ 10,000.00  | \$ 9,017.89   | \$ 982.11      |
| Garage Maint & Repairs                  | \$ 5,000.00   | \$ 5,087.45   | \$ (87.45)     |
| New Roads                               | \$ 115,000.00 | \$ 114,735.57 | \$ 264.43      |
| Tree Canopy Work                        | \$ 25,000.00  | \$ 24,937.46  | \$ 62.54       |
| Equipment Rental                        | \$ 18,000.00  | \$ 16,409.00  | \$ 1,591.00    |
| Vehicle Fuel                            | \$ 39,440.62  | \$ 33,600.50  | \$ 5,840.12    |
| Expense                                 | \$ 32,340.00  | \$ 29,441.19  | \$ 2,898.81    |
| <b>Snow &amp; Ice</b>                   |               |               |                |
| Salary                                  | \$ 22,000.00  | \$ 27,373.69  | \$ (5,373.69)  |
| Plow Supplies                           | \$ 15,000.00  | \$ 46,846.36  | \$ (31,846.36) |
| Fuel                                    | \$ 10,000.00  | \$ 9,181.45   | \$ 818.55      |
| Sand & Salt                             | \$ 62,000.00  | \$ 93,622.48  | \$ (31,622.48) |
| <b>Cemetery</b>                         |               |               |                |
| Stipend                                 | \$ 1,000.00   | \$ -          | \$ 1,000.00    |
| Expenses                                | \$ 19,000.00  | \$ 19,953.63  | \$ 1,800.00    |
| <b>Transfer Station/Board of Health</b> |               |               |                |
| Stipend                                 | \$ 5,000.00   | \$ 1,875.00   | \$ 3,125.00    |
| Salary - Secretary                      | \$ 15,000.00  | \$ 15,000.00  | \$ -           |
| Salary - Transfer Station Attendant     | \$ 27,771.00  | \$ 21,076.05  | \$ 6,694.95    |
| Building & Maint                        | \$ 15,000.00  | \$ 13,417.54  | \$ 1,582.46    |
| Cartage/Tipping                         | \$ 60,000.00  | \$ 60,292.27  | \$ (292.27)    |
| Expense                                 | \$ 25,000.00  | \$ 24,195.79  | \$ 804.21      |
| <b>Nursing Service</b>                  |               |               |                |
| Lee Visiting Nurse                      | \$ 2,000.00   | \$ 1,132.95   | \$ 867.05      |
| <b>Council on Aging</b>                 |               |               |                |
| Salary                                  | \$ 2,632.00   | \$ 1,383.64   | \$ 1,248.36    |
| Expense                                 | \$ 2,750.00   | \$ 3,207.93   | \$ (457.93)    |
| <b>Veterans Services</b>                |               |               |                |
| Services                                | \$ 2,000.00   | \$ 2,000.00   | \$ -           |
| Benefits                                | \$ 10,000.00  | \$ -          | \$ 10,000.00   |
| <b>Library</b>                          |               |               |                |
| Salary                                  | \$ 66,232.00  | \$ 65,570.63  | \$ 661.37      |
| Materials                               | \$ 18,976.00  | \$ 18,970.56  | \$ 5.44        |
| Expense                                 | \$ 10,338.00  | \$ 10,874.29  | \$ (536.29)    |
| <b>Recreation</b>                       |               |               |                |
| Expense                                 | \$ 4,400.00   | \$ 4,371.17   | \$ 28.83       |
| <b>Historical Commission</b>            |               |               |                |
| Consultant                              | \$ 5,000.00   |               | \$ 5,000.00    |
| Expense                                 | \$ 1,400.00   |               | \$ 1,400.00    |
| <b>Celebrations</b>                     |               |               |                |
| Expense                                 | \$ 1,700.00   | \$ 1,574.31   | \$ 125.69      |
| <b>Employee Benefits</b>                |               |               |                |
| County Retirement                       | \$ 143,000.00 | \$ 138,433.00 | \$ 4,567.00    |
| Workers Comp                            | \$ 12,746.00  | \$ -          | \$ 12,746.00   |
| Unemployment Comp                       | \$ 1,000.00   | \$ 42.17      | \$ 957.83      |
| Health Insurance                        | \$ 162,974.85 | \$ 65,502.79  | \$ 97,472.06   |

|                                    |           |                     |           |                     |           |                   |           |                   |
|------------------------------------|-----------|---------------------|-----------|---------------------|-----------|-------------------|-----------|-------------------|
| Life Insurance                     | \$        | 2,000.00            | \$        | 1,205.55            |           | \$                | 794.45    |                   |
| SS Medicare                        | \$        | 12,500.00           | \$        | 12,128.09           | \$        | 4.65              | \$        | 367.26            |
| Liability Insurance                | \$        | 100,087.00          | \$        | 98,692.50           |           |                   | \$        | 1,394.50          |
| <b>Prior Year Encumbrances</b>     |           |                     |           |                     |           |                   |           |                   |
| Expense                            | \$        | 137,737.34          | \$        | 116,387.34          |           |                   | \$        | 21,350.00         |
| <b>Special Articles</b>            |           |                     |           |                     |           |                   |           |                   |
| STM24 - Highway PYB                | \$        | 9,924.45            | \$        | 8,965.78            |           |                   | \$        | 958.67            |
| STM21 - Highway Garage OPM         | \$        | 3,052.42            | \$        | 3,052.42            |           |                   | \$        | -                 |
| STM24 - Mini Excavator             | \$        | 3,600.00            | \$        | -                   | \$        | 3,600.00          | \$        | -                 |
| STM24 - Library Feasibility        | \$        | 150,000.00          | \$        | -                   | \$        | 150,000.00        | \$        | -                 |
| ATM25 - Prior Year Bill            | \$        | 54.99               | \$        | 54.99               |           |                   | \$        | -                 |
| ATM25 - Prior Year Water Bills     | \$        | 30,176.00           | \$        | -                   | \$        | 30,176.00         | \$        | -                 |
| ATM25 - Clerk File Cabinet Safe    | \$        | 10,000.00           | \$        | -                   | \$        | 10,000.00         | \$        | -                 |
| ATM23 - Fire/Highway Facility Proj | \$        | 170,492.12          | \$        | 4,737.30            | \$        | 165,754.82        | \$        | -                 |
| ATM23 - Library Masonry Repairs    | \$        | 9,050.00            | \$        | -                   |           |                   | \$        | 9,050.00          |
| ATM24 - Town Building Assessment   | \$        | 50,000.00           | \$        | -                   | \$        | 50,000.00         | \$        | -                 |
| STM22 - Porter Library Feasibility | \$        | 10,000.00           | \$        | 1,536.27            | \$        | 8,463.73          | \$        | -                 |
| STM22 - Repair Fire Garage         | \$        | 994.85              | \$        | -                   |           |                   | \$        | 994.85            |
| STM24 - COA New Vehicle            | \$        | 40,000.00           | \$        | 23,319.16           | \$        | 16,680.84         | \$        | -                 |
| <b>General Fund Totals</b>         | <b>\$</b> | <b>5,045,192.29</b> | <b>\$</b> | <b>4,255,506.20</b> | <b>\$</b> | <b>443,447.05</b> | <b>\$</b> | <b>346,239.04</b> |

**General Fund Revenue Received 2025**

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|                                |    |                     |
|--------------------------------|----|---------------------|
| PERSONAL PROPERTY - 2023       | \$ | 18.14               |
| PERSONAL PROPERTY - 2024       | \$ | 13,368.77           |
| PERSONAL PROPERTY - 2025       | \$ | 847,552.72          |
| REAL ESTATE - 2022             | \$ | 377.34              |
| REAL ESTATE - 2023             | \$ | 863.77              |
| REAL ESTATE - 2024             | \$ | 12,879.12           |
| REAL ESTATE - 2025             | \$ | 2,615,966.26        |
| MOTOR VEHICLE EXCISE - 2021    | \$ | 189.75              |
| MOTOR VEHICLE EXCISE - 2022    | \$ | 810.38              |
| MOTOR VEHICLE EXCISE - 2023    | \$ | 4,341.15            |
| MOTOR VEHICLE EXCISE - 2024    | \$ | 29,527.25           |
| MOTOR VEHICLE EXCISE - 2025    | \$ | 201,286.97          |
| MISCELLANEOUS TAXES            | \$ | 328.31              |
| PENALTIES & INTEREST TAXES     | \$ | 12,104.65           |
| PAYMENT IN LIEU OF TAXES       | \$ | 224,908.88          |
| TAX COLLECTOR FEES             | \$ | 11,935.00           |
| POLICE FEES                    | \$ | 10,097.75           |
| FIRE FEES                      | \$ | 180.00              |
| CONSERVATION FEES              | \$ | 1,282.50            |
| PLANNING BOARD FEES            | \$ | 705.00              |
| BOARD OF HEALTH FEES           | \$ | 2,661.00            |
| TOWN CLERK FEES                | \$ | 812.20              |
| MISCELLANEOUS FEES             | \$ | 525.00              |
| TRANSFER STATION               | \$ | 22,936.50           |
| RENTALS                        | \$ | 13,080.96           |
| MISCELLANEOUS LICENSE          | \$ | 200.00              |
| POLICE PERMITS                 | \$ | 1,581.25            |
| BUILDING PERMITS               | \$ | 17,699.82           |
| PLUMBING PERMITS               | \$ | 270.00              |
| ELECTRICAL PERMITS             | \$ | 670.00              |
| CHAPTER 70 FUNDS               | \$ | 77,586.00           |
| TRANSPORTATION                 | \$ | 5,576.00            |
| UNRESTRICTED GOVERNMENT AID    | \$ | 156,348.00          |
| VETERANS & ELDERLY EXEMPTION   | \$ | 38,625.00           |
| STATE OWNED LAND               | \$ | 39,837.00           |
| MEALS TAX                      | \$ | 35,825.06           |
| VARIOUS FINES AND FEES         | \$ | 12,059.22           |
| INVESTMENT INCOME              | \$ | 47,705.53           |
| TAX LIENS                      | \$ | 39,023.36           |
| PENALTIES & INTEREST TAX TITLE | \$ | 15,984.90           |
| MISCELLANEOUS REVENUE          | \$ | 8,774.19            |
| TRANSFER TO OTHER FUNDS        | \$ | 172,546.08          |
|                                | \$ | <u>4,699,050.78</u> |

**SPECIAL REVENUE FUNDS**

|                                              |    |             |               |
|----------------------------------------------|----|-------------|---------------|
| Grant - Emergency Management                 | \$ | (761.97)    |               |
| Grant - ARPA                                 | \$ | 4,919.66    |               |
| Grant - ARPA Storm Relief                    | \$ | 10,059.00   |               |
| Grant - COA HVES                             | \$ | 1,418.66    |               |
| Broadband - CAF II Funds                     | \$ | 107,763.92  |               |
| Grant - Cyber Security                       | \$ | (45,000.00) |               |
| Grant - Fire Safe                            | \$ | 5,503.81    |               |
| Grant - Water Operations                     | \$ | 8,948.54    |               |
| Grant - COA Better Together                  | \$ | 8,742.64    |               |
| Grant - RDP Recycling                        | \$ | (5,755.00)  |               |
| Grant - Library State Aid                    | \$ | 22,557.75   |               |
| Grant - COA Formula                          | \$ | 9,452.18    |               |
| Grant - Cultural Council                     | \$ | 7,189.26    |               |
| Donation - Cultural Council                  | \$ | 973.16      |               |
| Grant - EDC REDO                             | \$ | 10,950.56   |               |
| Grant - Board of Health Covid 19             | \$ | 656.73      |               |
| Grant - Firefighter Equipment                | \$ | 9,111.55    |               |
| Grant - Elections                            | \$ | 4,194.39    |               |
| Grant - Municipal Vulnerability Preparedness | \$ | 16.71       |               |
| Grant - Mass Works Beech Hill                | \$ | 19,604.64   |               |
| Grant - Dept of Transportation Fair Share    | \$ | 985.21      |               |
| Grant - Library LTC                          | \$ | 1,158.59    |               |
| Grant - HMPG                                 | \$ | 8,400.00    |               |
| Grant - Library Planning & Design            | \$ | 78,353.90   |               |
| Grant - Municipal Library Small Population   | \$ | 14,083.65   |               |
| Transportation Network                       | \$ | 21.00       |               |
| Wetlands Protection                          | \$ | 1,978.27    |               |
| Insurance                                    | \$ | 6,580.47    |               |
| Revolving - Fire Department                  | \$ | 17,637.05   |               |
| Revolving - Board of Health Inspection       | \$ | 876.35      |               |
| Revolving - COA                              | \$ | 13,636.19   |               |
| Revolving - Electrical Inspector             | \$ | 241.00      |               |
| Revolving - Board of Health Demo             | \$ | 1,788.35    |               |
| Revolving - Plumbing Inspector               | \$ | (1,905.00)  |               |
| Donation - COA                               | \$ | 34.00       |               |
| Donation - Fire Dept                         | \$ | 67.57       |               |
| Donation - Recreation                        | \$ | 13.03       |               |
| Donation - Skating Rink                      | \$ | 395.00      |               |
| Donation - Berkshire Trail Riders            | \$ | 50.00       |               |
| Donation - Building Painting                 | \$ | 14.97       |               |
| Septic Loan Program                          | \$ | 26,302.04   |               |
| HCI Watson Park Arborist Inventory           | \$ | 217.50      |               |
| Opioid Settlement                            | \$ | 641.34      |               |
| CTCL Elections                               | \$ | 31.73       |               |
| GRSD Intern Grant                            | \$ | 876.00      |               |
| Conservation - Shepard                       | \$ | 1,165.00    |               |
| Planning - G Millard                         | \$ | 12,208.90   |               |
| Planning - Otis Stage                        | \$ | 3,202.87    |               |
| Planning - Fleur Marijuana                   | \$ | 2,517.52    |               |
| Conservation - Fleur Marijuana               | \$ | 901.62      | \$ 373,020.31 |

**CAPITAL PROJECTS**

|               |    |    |           |
|---------------|----|----|-----------|
| Town Projects | 15 | \$ | 53,579.15 |
|---------------|----|----|-----------|

|                                             |                |                        |
|---------------------------------------------|----------------|------------------------|
| Water                                       | \$ (42,861.38) | <u>\$ 10,717.77</u>    |
| <b>ENTERPRISE FUNDS</b>                     |                |                        |
| Broadband                                   | \$ 498,928.37  |                        |
| Water                                       | \$ 464,641.23  | <u>\$ 963,569.60</u>   |
| <b>EXPENDABLE TRUSTS &amp; AGENCY FUNDS</b> |                |                        |
| Fire Arms License                           | \$ 1,325.00    |                        |
| Deputy Collector Fees                       | \$ (46.00)     |                        |
| Town Clerk Fees                             | \$ 781.40      |                        |
| Conservation - Southern Hill Town           | \$ 283.53      |                        |
| Planning - Peebles Brook Solar              | \$ 9,096.94    |                        |
| Planning - Gibbs Brook Solar                | \$ 9,650.54    | <u>\$ 21,091.41</u>    |
| Trust - Arms Bicentennial                   | \$ 23,835.04   |                        |
| Trust - Watson Dean Park                    | \$ 514,343.01  |                        |
| Trust - Cemetery 1 & 2                      | \$ 16,162.30   |                        |
| Trust - Soenburger Cemetery                 | \$ 2,825.95    |                        |
| Trust - Sarah Robbins                       | \$ 26,999.85   |                        |
| Trust - Cemetery                            | \$ 7,828.06    |                        |
| Trust - School Taggart                      | \$ 9,971.17    |                        |
| Trust - School Nye                          | \$ 8,716.23    |                        |
| Trust - School Watson                       | \$ 5,556.80    |                        |
| Trust - Electa/Watson                       | \$ 121,030.04  |                        |
| Trust - Susan Tiffany Cemetery              | \$ 82,481.18   |                        |
| Cemetery Lots for Sale                      | \$ 18,082.49   | <u>\$ 837,832.12</u>   |
| <b>STABILIZATION FUNDS</b>                  |                |                        |
| General Stabilization                       | \$ 759,482.47  |                        |
| Capital Stabilization                       | \$ 87,287.55   |                        |
| Building Projects Stabilization             | \$ 830,260.18  |                        |
| Library Building Statbilization             | \$ 70,691.48   |                        |
| Education Stabilization                     | \$ 126,851.06  |                        |
| Broadband Stabilization                     | \$ 136,553.31  |                        |
| Water Stabilization                         | \$ 166,710.17  |                        |
| OPEB                                        | \$ 50,000.00   | <u>\$ 2,227,836.22</u> |
| Total Agency & Trust                        |                | <u>\$ 3,086,759.75</u> |

## **Ad-Hoc Advisory Committee on the Climate Leader Community Designation**

The Ad-Hoc Advisory Committee on Climate Leader Community (CLC) Designation was established by the Blandford Select Board in June 2025. The committee, consisting of volunteers Chuck Benson, Paul Dirschka, and Debbie Lundgren, was charged with (1) researching the requirements, application process, and steps required to obtain the CLC designation; (2) identifying potential financial and administrative implications for the town in pursuing the designation; (3) gathering examples and lessons learned from other towns seeking or having obtained the designation; and (4) reporting findings and recommendations to the town regarding pursuit of the CLC designation.

The committee met eight times from June – October 2025, and the final report was presented to the Select Board on November 24, 2025. Key findings were as follows:

- (1) Requirements to successfully attain CLC status include (a) being a Green Community in good standing; b) establishing an advisory committee to advise the town, coordinate clean energy projects, and carry out the remaining four requirements for CLC designation; (c) committing to elimination of fossil fuel use by 2050\*; (d) establishing a plan for decarbonization of municipal buildings and vehicles by 2050; (e) adopting a zero emissions vehicle first policy to eventually phase out gas-powered vehicles\*; and (f) adopting the Specialized Energy Code\*. \*Indicates that this article must be passed by town vote.
- (2) Blandford expressed concerns about potential financial and administrative costs associated with pursuing the CLC designation, particularly for a small town like Blandford (pop. 1215). To address these concerns, we explored the experiences of two small Massachusetts towns who attained CLC status in May 2025. These included Ashfield (pop. 1700) and Pelham (pop. 1250). Ashfield provides extensive online documentation of their implementation plan. Their documentation, together with frequent conversations with Chris Mason, Green Community Coordinator for Western Massachusetts, sufficiently addressed the town's concerns.
- (3) Our committee unanimously agreed that the potential benefits of achieving Climate Leader status were well worth the effort required. CLC grants of up to \$1 million can fund large-scale decarbonization projects, such as solar panels on Blandford's municipal buildings, providing long-term financial benefits. As an example, Ashfield has recently been awarded a CLC grant of \$870,872 for a solar system at its wastewater treatment plant and highway garage. This project is estimated to save nearly \$100,000 in energy costs.

## ASSESSORS

State law requires assessors to estimate the fair market value of all properties within their jurisdiction. Assessed valuations are based on “full and fair cash value” as of January 1 preceding each fiscal year. To maintain assessments at or near market value, the assessors regularly compare property valuations with the selling prices of properties that have sold.

Assessment-to-sale ratio statistics are analyzed to determine the median assessment level and maintain assessment uniformity. A secondary, and perhaps more important, function of the Board of Assessors is to generate equitable assessments. To that end, we continually strive to maintain an accurate property database and refine valuation tables and formulas that yield both equitable and explainable assessments.

With this mandate comes the requirement that assessors conduct annual revaluations. Revaluations not only respond to the ever-changing real estate market but are opportunities for assessors to improve the quality of property data, estimate values that more closely correspond to the market, as evidenced by property sales, and improve the underlying valuation methods used to estimate values. Each of these functions must be approved by the Massachusetts Department of Revenue - DOR.

If you observe a change in your valuation, the difference can be attributed to one or more of the following:

- Market appreciation
- Building permit-related construction and improvements
- Inspections made as part of our periodic inspection program, from which the features listed on assessment records are updated

Assessed valuations are not intended to predict what a property might sell for in the future. By law, assessors are only concerned with what properties were worth on the assessment date – the January 1 preceding the fiscal year of taxation. The assessment date for fiscal year 2027 is January 1, 2026. Properties that sold in the 12 months preceding the assessment date affect fiscal year 2026 valuations. Many factors influence what a buyer might pay for a property, but only those that are readily quantifiable are used in estimating your valuation. For example, your assessment is based on features like location, land area, building area, type and grade of construction, age and condition, and amenities like garages, swimming pools, and finished basements. Examples of property features not considered in your assessment include curb appeal, home décor, and landscaping.

Town revenue comes from several sources. These include state funds (the so-called “Cherry Sheet”), motor vehicle excise taxes, town revenue (investment income, departmental fees, PILOT payments, meals tax, etc.), enterprise income (water and internet), and amounts voted from Free Cash or Reserve Accounts. All expenditures are voted on during town meetings based upon a recommended budget from the Finance Committee. The actual amount of real estate tax levied on a property is a result of the amount of money needed to be raised to cover expenses after all other revenue is accounted for (yielding the property tax levy). This amount is then applied to the real estate valuation to determine a tax rate (which also has to be approved by the Massachusetts Department of Revenue), which is then applied to the assessed valuation of each property to yield a tax bill.

After receiving the first actual bill for the Fiscal Year, you may seek an abatement by filing with our office. Abatement forms may be found outside of the Assessors’ office, and you must file by the date noted on the tax bill (Applications for abatements are due on or before the due date for payment of the 3rd quarter bill). Assessors are prohibited by law from acting on untimely applications and are unable to waive those requirements. If you are unsatisfied with the Assessors’ decisions on your abatement, you may file with the State’s Appellate Tax Board (ATB) by using the information found on the abatement form.

For additional information, please visit the Assessors page on the town’s website.

Dr. David Hopson, Chair

## BUILDING DEPARTMENT

One hundred and five permits were issued by the building department during FY 2025 which is well above average compared to previous years. Two new single family dwelling permits were issued, while fourteen more were for major home renovations, additions, or large garage/barn projects.

Three commercial permits were issued as well.

Twenty-six energy conservation permits pulled this year including solar installations, window/ replacements, and insulation and air sealing upgrades. Twelve permits were also issued for wood or pellet stoves.

Please note that the installation of any solid-fuel burning appliance (wood stoves, pellet stoves, etc.) requires a permit, regardless of the installer. The fee for this permit is reasonable, required by all home insurance companies, and important to the safety of the inhabitants of the structure. If you have already installed one of these devices, you can still apply for a permit and have a quick inspection.

The remaining permits issued included those for sheds, roofing, etc.

A continued effort is being made to try and more strictly enforce our zoning bylaws to maintain property values and the public safety of all residents. Please feel free to reach out any time with any concerns you may have throughout town and I will address accordingly. In the coming years, we plan to continue to take numerous actions to clean up several of the blighted properties around town. Sometimes these actions take longer than anticipated due to the legal process but the effort will continue.

A large thank you goes out to all the other town departments and boards for their assistance and cooperation when requested. The dedication of these numerous, primarily volunteer, individuals is greatly appreciated and a testament to their commitment to the betterment of our town.

I am consistently in the area so please feel free to reach out to me anytime at (413) 205-6504. Copies of each type of building permit application can be found on the website for you to download at your convenience if the online permitting system is not a viable option. I can also mail you a copy of the application if desired.

Respectfully submitted,  
Jason Forge, Building Commissioner

Chester-Blandford Police Department  
Annual Report  
Fiscal Year 2025

Message from the Chief of Police

On behalf of the men and women of the Chester-Blandford Police Department, I am proud to present our Fiscal Year 2025 Annual Report.

With a team of just eight sworn officers, our department continues to demonstrate that professionalism, dedication, and community partnership are not defined by size, but by commitment. This year, our officers responded to emergencies, investigated serious crimes, supported families in crisis, and worked proactively to improve roadway safety throughout our community.

Among our most notable accomplishments was the successful disruption of a multistate vehicle theft operation, reflecting the professionalism and investigative skills of our detective and officers. We also secured funding to continue operating drug take-back kiosks at both the Blandford and Chester town halls, ensuring residents have a safe and responsible way to dispose of unused medications.

Every day, our officers balance enforcement with compassion. Whether responding to medical emergencies, assisting at crash scenes, supporting victims of domestic disturbances, or working to slow traffic on our roadways, our mission remains the same: protect life, preserve peace, and serve with integrity.

We are grateful for the continued support of our community and look forward to building on this year's progress.

Sincerely,  
Jen Dubiel  
Chief of Police

## **Conservation Commission Annual Report –February 2026**

The Blandford Conservation Commission (BCC) has continued to administer the Massachusetts Wetlands Protection Act and provide oversight of Town owned conservation land under its control. The current Commission members are Dick Gates (Chair), John Piper, Colleen Doyle, Nathan Maynard, and Corinne Shartrand. For the first time in many years, we have a complete Commission with five members. In addition, Sabrina Pooler is our new Conservation Agent/Coordinator, and we are excited to have her on board.

Activities of the BCC related to the Wetlands Protection Act have included reviewing Requests for Determination, issuing Determinations of Applicability, reviewing projects, issuing Orders of Conditions (Permits) for those projects, issuing amended Orders of Conditions and Extensions of Orders. Additional activities include reviewing local building permits and issuing hunting permits for the Knittel, Shephard Farm, and Long Pond Conservation Areas. Specially, the Commission has recently reviewed Requests for Determinations for two large scale solar facilities and is anticipating receiving Notices of Intent for the proposed Eversource Substation expansion and a Battery Storage Facility both proposed for North Blandford Road.

The Commission has also been working closely with Town officials and the Energy Project Siting & Engagement Committee. The goal of these efforts has been to establish a Town moratorium on new Energy Facilities, update the Town Zoning By-laws, implement new Town Wetland Bylaws/Regulations, and interact with the State Energy Facility Siting Board.

In accordance with the Town's Open Space and Recreation Plan, the longer term-goals of the BCC are to develop more passive recreational use of the Town owned Conservation Properties, and this would include improved parking areas and hiking trail development at Long Pond and Shephard Farm.

The Commission worked with Massachusetts Department of Conservation and Recreation to update the Forest Stewardship Plan for Shepard Farm under a cost share program with the State.

Dick Gates, Chair

## COUNCIL ON AGING

The Blandford Council on Aging is pleased to report that we have had another successful year of offering programs and transportation. Even though the vehicle that was donated to us by Julie Mueller had to be taken off the road due to safety concerns, our volunteer drivers continued to provide transportation with their own vehicles. Thank you to our volunteers.

The main mission of the Council on Aging is to serve our senior community, we are here to lend a hand to anyone who needs it, in any way we can. Our doors are open to all, young and old. Come and join us on the first Friday of the month from 2 – 4' for a game of cards, or a board game, or just to socialize and get to know us.

Sue Racine continues to fill the room for a watercolor painting class. This class is held on the first Tuesday of the month at 10:00 a.m. Beginners are welcome to join. This class is paid for through a grant.

Heidi's Monday morning class of Balance, Strength, and Flexibility continues to draw a good crowd from Blandford residents, as well as those from out of town. The class is free to Blandford residents. The cost is \$5.00 for all others.

Our bi-monthly meals continue to be successful. Again, these are not just for the seniors in town. Anyone is welcome to come and join us. We ask for a \$5.00 donation to keep this program running. We do not receive money for this from any grants or the town budget. It is strictly supported by the donations we receive from the people who attend. A huge thank you to Joann for all the wonderful meals and to all the other volunteers who help to make this the success it is.

Margit J. Mikuski, Director; Joann Martin, Chair; Barb Langmore, Bob Twyman, Heidi Taberman and Pat Lombardo, board members

## Cultural Council

The Cultural Council Received \$5,700. in grant money from the Mass Lottery funding. We had encumbered funds from last year and we also had interest earned in the amount of \$179.37 and discretionary Council funds in the amount of \$125.

The council retains 5% of the funds mandated by the state for administrative expenses if needed.

We awarded money to the following grantees:

|                                                                            |        |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------|
| Becket Arts Center for year-round Multi Arts Programs                      | \$575  |
| Blandford Art Show for supplies and judges.                                | \$800  |
| Blandford Historical Society for Bel Canto Opera                           | \$1500 |
| Steven Cormier for Good Golly Missed Trolley                               | \$200  |
| Ron Druyan for Tiny Tutti, a musical experience for 3-6 yrs                | \$675  |
| Gateway Regional High School bus to Mass MOCA                              | \$250  |
| Gateway Regional School for guest Artist series                            | \$500  |
| Hilltown Community Health Centers form poop Museum.                        | \$500  |
| Hilltown Village Creative Movement for Hilltown families<br>4-week series. | \$150  |
| Ken Longstreet for Bad News Jazz/Blues Orchestra.                          | \$400  |
| Tracy Kochanski for the Art of Felting.                                    | \$575  |
| Vic Thomas for Blues Brothers Band; 2 hour concert                         | \$400  |

Susan Racine, Chair; Lisa Bruno, Cindy Carr, Janet Strausberg and Amy Hagstrom, members

## **ENERGY PROJECT SITING & ENGAGEMENT COMMITTEE**

### **Successful Work of the EPSEC Committee**

On September 24, 2025, the Energy Project Siting & Engagement Committee (EPSEC) was formed shortly after the Town pursued a temporary moratorium related to large-scale energy development projects.

The creation of EPSEC came in response to several major developments impacting the Town, including the State's new energy permitting laws, the proposed expansion of the Eversource substation, and an increasing influx of commercial solar and Battery Energy Storage System proposals. Recognizing that these changes could significantly increase development pressure in the community, the Town assembled a diverse working group to proactively review and strengthen local bylaws and regulations.

The committee was tasked with evaluating and updating the Town's Solar and BESS bylaws, as well as creating an Energy Overlay Map, to better prepare Blandford for future project volume while balancing energy policy, public safety, environmental protection, and preservation of community character.

The committee met twice a month for eight months, reviewed countless state hearing and regulatory documents, and worked collaboratively to help define what will become Blandford's local energy laws for the future.

The committee's collaborative work brought together municipal leadership, board and committee representatives, public safety officials, and residents to help ensure the Town is better positioned to respond thoughtfully and responsibly to future energy project proposals.

#### **Committee members:**

Jackie Coury, Selectboard  
Greg Garfield, Planning  
Dick Gates, Conservation  
Kim Bergland, Zoning  
Jen Girard, Board of Health  
Adam Dolby, Fire Chief  
Richard Meczywor, Resident  
Corinne Shartrand, Resident  
Trae Jelinek, Resident  
Dave Converse, Resident

## FINANCE COMMITTEE

There were four members of the committee for the full year. At the end of the 2025 fiscal year, we lost 3/4 of the committee. Jackie Coury was elected to the Select Board. Kevin Green and Janet Lombardo resigned their positions. Thank you to all of them for their valuable contributions as part of the committee.

The committee had a very slow start to the new year, but we are back up to speed. The Finance Committee should be a committee of five and cannot act in a voting capacity unless there is a quorum of three people.

In October, Sarah Malanson joined me on the committee. Sarah and I attended Select Board meetings to keep on top of things. In early January, Allyson Keyes joined the committee. Both brought knowledge and great skills. Thanks for joining me, Sarah and Allyson. Sarah was voted as the Finance Committee Secretary.

January started the budget cycle for fiscal 2026. Cristina Ferrera, the Town Administrator announces the budget cycle with forms, instructions and scheduling which go to Department Heads. When completed, she organizes the paperwork and hands it off to the committee. We could not have gotten through the budget without Cristina's help. Thank you, Cristina.

From there, the Committee met with Department heads to review their needs for the next year. Then, the Committee meets and discusses requests for the budgets. We then meet with the Select board with our recommendations. The Budget goes before the Residents at the Town of Blandford Annual Town Meeting.

We hope to see you at the Annual Town Meeting in June.

Deborah Brodie, Chair  
Sarah Malanson, Secretary  
Allyson Keyes, Member

## **FIRE DEPARTMENT**

In 2025, the Blandford Fire Department responded to roughly 100 calls with our all-volunteer force. We have been fortunate to maintain our ranks of volunteers and appreciate their dedication to training and service to the town.

Equipment costs rose dramatically in 2025 and the department continues to work to replace equipment smartly - often downsizing the amount of gear that we have or finding better and more efficient ways of deploying that equipment.

The department ordered our new brush truck, with the help of supplemental funding from Springfield Water. Originally slated for May, the truck delivery timeline has been impacted by supply chain issues and is now expected in the June/July timeframe. With the constantly shifting tariff environment, we are optimistic we will avoid a \$45,000 tariff on the truck (as initially projected) which would impact our funding and ability to equip the truck.

Engine 1 will be next on the replacement list - with current station size requirements limiting options for the apparatus we can purchase.

No progress has been made on replacing the fire station. With roughly 2 inches of clearance on either side of trucks, repairs and replacement parts when trucks are damaged entering/leaving the station continue to mount.

The department would like to remind all residents to ensure they have working smoke and CO detectors in their houses as well as displaying their house number visibly from the road.

Adam Dolby  
Fire Chief  
Blandford Fire Dept.

## BOARD OF HEALTH

We are exiting our 2025-2026 year stronger than before and are excited to bring new things once again next year.

As our team continues to bring the health, safety and welfare to residents. Our Health Care program is growing and we are so proud to offer these programs to our residents. As the new year approaches, we have more health care programs to offer.

Home Health Care Program has been very successful. We have had residents take advantage of this service and anyone who is interested in a home health care check or would like to know more about our program, please contact us at [boh@townofblandford.gov](mailto:boh@townofblandford.gov).

Blood Pressure & Glucose screening is available every second Monday of the Month. Residents come to the town hall to have our tech monitor their blood pressure and/or glucose levels.

We partnered with the American Red Cross, and now provide blood pressure equipment so residents may come to the town hall and take their own blood pressure anytime the town hall is open or you can barrow a blood pressure from the library and take it home for a period of time.

We continue to partner with Southwick/Western Hampden Public Health Distract. We have Maryann Deming, who continues to provide blood pressure checks at the exercise classes and COA breakfast/lunch programs. Maryann also provides us with posters and information on numerous health topics and our vaccine clinics.

Not only has our Health Care Program grown, our Transfer Station has grown with a swap shack. As the saying goes someone's junk is someone else's treasures. We also added a paint shop. Residents can now dispose of their old paint. For more information stop by and see one of our tenants Tuesday or Saturday.

| PERMTS           |    | COMPLAINTS    |   | HEALTH          |    |
|------------------|----|---------------|---|-----------------|----|
| Food Permits     | 6  | Environmental | 1 | Covid-19        | 15 |
| Cottage Kitchens | 0  | Housing       | 3 | Flu             | 5  |
| Camp             | 1  | Condemned     | 0 | TB              | 0  |
| Tobacco          | 3  | Insects       | 1 | Chronic Disease | 6  |
| Beaver           | 3  | Hazardous     | 2 |                 |    |
| Hauling          | 2  | Nuisance      | 5 |                 |    |
| Well             | 3  | Water         | 1 |                 |    |
| Perc             | 8  |               |   |                 |    |
| Septic           | 12 |               |   |                 |    |

The Blandford Board of Health is responsible by state statutes to perform crucial duties relative to the protection of public health, control of disease, promotion of sanitary living and the protection of the environment from damage and pollution.

Our board of health protects the public through education, inspections while overseeing communicable diseases, emergency preparedness, sanitary conditions, food establishments, beaver trapping, percolation tests, subsurface sewerage, well installations and the transfer station.

These requirements reflect the legislature's understanding that many critical health problems are best handled by the involvement of the local community officials familiar with the local conditions.

Bret Hartley, Chair, Jennifer Girard and Pat Lombardo, members

## **Blandford Highway Department**

Blandford Highway's overview of FY25 and upcoming FY26 I would like to thank the residents of Blandford and its Select Board for the opportunity to demonstrate my skills and strengths in serving our community as Highway Superintendent.

When I began in 2025, the Highway Department was operating without a full working crew. Since then, I have built a strong and dependable workforce capable of completing the many tasks and specialized projects needed throughout Blandford.

Through in-house training, I have provided the crew with essential, hands-on skills required for daily operations and for meeting the town's specific needs. The team has excelled in refurbishing and repairing the town's equipment in-house rather than relying on costly outsourcing. Their dedication and growing expertise have exceeded my expectations, saving the town money while strengthening the department's overall capabilities. With a new crew in place, it was important to ensure proper training and adherence to safety standards.

With the assistance of the Board of Health and University of Massachusetts Amherst, we participated in hands-on training courses to stay current with safety procedures and professional standards. This reinforced our commitment to a safety-first approach in all that we do. The Highway Department truly "hit the ground running" with several long-overdue projects. We completed general maintenance on Blandford's dirt roads using proper materials and methods, receiving positive feedback from residents as we progressed through town.

Posting roads during mud season was also critical to preventing damage during the spring thaw. Another major accomplishment was the resurfacing of Cobble Mountain Road and South Street Extension. After years of deterioration, addressing these roads now will help avoid more costly repairs in the future, saving both time and money that can be directed to other needed improvements.

These projects were completed using Chapter 90 funding. We also addressed several concerning utility pole issues in coordination with Eversource and Verizon. The poles were reset at no cost to the town, thanks to their cooperation. In September, heavy winds brought down multiple trees, causing power outages and dangerous road closures. Thanks to the crew's quick response and ability to work safely under hazardous conditions along with strong communication with our Fire and Police Departments and assistance from Eversource—we were able to restore normal operations within a few days.

Throughout the year, the department's progress was never limited by a lack of workers or motivation only by the number of hours in a day. The crew consistently showed up ready to work and take direction, completing and exceeding the expectations set before us. In the fall of 2025, we began preparations on the lower section of Russell Stage Road for a planned 2026 resurfacing and drainage project, again utilizing Chapter 90 funds. Looking ahead to spring, I am confident in my crew's ability to complete roadside work, tree trimming, asphalt repair, and the proper cleaning and storage of winter equipment to prevent costly repairs.

I would like to thank the residents and the town administration for your continued support and trust. With your ongoing support, we will continue working to make the Town of Blandford a safer and more enjoyable place for all.

Highway Superintendent, Raymond Hultay

**HILLTOWN COMMUNITY AMBULANCE ASSOCIATION, INC.**  
**TOWN OF BLANDFORD**  
**1/1/25 - 12/31/25**

**Operations:**

Hilltown Community Ambulance Association, Inc. (HCAA) is the primary ambulance service provider for the Town of Blandford. The other towns located within our primary service area include Chester, Huntington, Montgomery, Russell, and Worthington, covering approximately 8100 individuals over approximately 220 sq. mi. HCAA also provides mutual aid responses to the Towns of Middlefield and Becket, as well as being assisted with mutual aid services by our neighboring Cities/Towns of Westfield, Northampton, and Becket when the need arises.

HCAA is a 24/7 service and was staffed at the paramedic level 100% of the time for the period of 2025. Our fleet consists of 2 ambulances that are in service and, when a second crew is available, both ambulances are able to respond to calls.

**Town Events/Community Education:**

In addition to being the primary provider of ambulance services, we also provide standby services at the annual Blandford Fair for the various scheduled events. HCAA also participated in the annual Health & Wellness Fair, allowing us the opportunity to interact with our neighbors and friends firsthand and provide any resources or answer any questions that may arise.

HCAA provides education and training to residents of the community that are free of charge. During 2025, HCAA presented multiple Naloxone (Narcan) familiarization courses to inform individuals on the benefits and how to administer should an overdose emergency arise. HCAA also provides a variety of certification courses, including American Heart Association BLS CPR and AED, for a registration fee. Keep an eye out on our social media platforms for upcoming classes and blood pressure drives, as well as visit our website for what classes are offered. If you are interested in participating or hosting a class that is not scheduled, please do not hesitate to reach out.

**Emergency Responses:**

| Town        | Number of Calls | Percentage of Total Calls |
|-------------|-----------------|---------------------------|
| Blandford   | 92              | 10.5%                     |
| Chester     | 163             | 18.6%                     |
| Huntington  | 206             | 23.5%                     |
| Montgomery  | 88              | 10.1%                     |
| Mutual Aid  | 14              | 1.6%                      |
| Russell     | 154             | 17.6%                     |
| Worthington | 158             | 18.1%                     |

*In 2025, HCAA responded to a total of 895 calls for service within the surrounding 6 towns and neighboring communities (See table).*

Respectfully Submitted,  
Jade Rice- Chief Financial Officer

**PORTER MEMORIAL LIBRARY  
DIRECTOR'S REPORT  
2025**

Over the past year, Porter Memorial Library has continued to provide patrons with excellent service and access to a variety of valuable resources. In addition to myself, our hard-working staff of library techs- Kim Chaffee and Michele Crane, and archivist Sam Stevens, have significantly increased foot traffic, circulation, programming, and patron registration.

The 2025 summer reading program focused on creativity and art making- kids learned how to do printmaking, tie dye, sculpt, and more! In September, kids came to the library to stuff their backpack with books to keep. Halloween and Winter Vacation also featured a book giveaway for kids.

Attendance at our adult programming has been steadily increasing. With the help of Lucia Sullivan and Michele Crane the adult book club has continued to grow and reach new readers - this year the book club read 12 books in a range of genres and hosted lively monthly discussions about the readings. Every month between 12 and 25 people participate in the club, maximizing library occupancy limits.

The Library hosted multiple well attended Community Meetings for the building design process. In December, town residents voted unanimously to support the library's continuation to the Construction phase of the Massachusetts Board of Library Commissioners' grant to expand the library building.

In conclusion, 2025 was a year of historic growth and community support for the library. We are grateful for the support of the town and look forward to continuing to improve and serve the community of Blandford over the next year.

Respectfully submitted,

Nicole Daviau  
Director

## LIBRARY TRUSTEES

The Trustees have been working with Library Director Nicole Daviau and the staff at the library throughout the year looking forward to the expansion project. Which, we are pleased to note, the planning and design phase, was completed three months ahead of schedule and under budget. All thanks to Director Daviau's hard work and generous enthusiasm. The success of the expansion is her doing.

And a special thank you to all the library supporters who unanimously voted to accept the construction grant from the Massachusetts Board of Library Commissioners at the Special Town Meeting in December 2025.

We look forward to the new facility in 2027 and are truly grateful to everyone on the Building Committee, and especially the staff: Kim Chaffee, Michele Crane, Sam Stevens, Lucia Sullivan, Claire Whitley and Nathan Crane.

The library will be in the Town Hall with the same hours of operation.

Watch the progress as it moves along.

Mary Kronholm, Chair  
Amy Hagstrom, Treasurer  
Byam Stevens, Secretary

## **BLANDFORD MUNICIPAL LIGHT PLANT**

The Fiber to the Home (FTTH) project is complete and fully operational. Service connections to Blandford homes began in the Spring of 2021. The network is owned by Blandford. Westfield Gas & Electric (Whip City Fiber) is the Internet Service Provider (ISP), and Network Operator (NO). There are 52.8 miles of fiber installed.

There are currently 435 customers, or approximately 88% of residences, signed up for the internet service. In addition, there are 103 phone subscribers.

It took several years to first design the network and then make the utility poles ready to install fiber network. Many poles had to be replaced and throughout the town existing electric and telephone lines had to be moved to allow room for fiber to be attached to the poles. Several areas such as turnpike crossings required custom engineering solutions and special permissions. Sertex began the actual construction on November 30, 2020. Constructing the fiber network was a 3 step process: Installing steel strand on poles, lashing Fiber to the strand, and finally installing MST's. The Town is divided into five (5) Fiber Service Areas (FSA's).

The Network Hub is located at 4 North Blandford Rd, and includes a Hut, generator and propane backup. We currently have 10 gigs of service into the Town. As of this writing, there have been no interruptions in the service.

If you are new to town, or have not yet done so, sign-ups can be done online through the website: [www.whipcityfiber.com/blandford](http://www.whipcityfiber.com/blandford) or by going to the Town of Blandford website. The cost for the service is only \$85 per month, plus installation costs.

The Blandford MLP wishes to thank all of you for the tremendous support you have given to this project!

Fiber is now available to 100% of homes in Blandford; Also, in partnership with our ISP and the Towns of Otis, Becket and Washington (Southern Cluster) a redundant network is now operational. This will insure that, in the event of an outage into any one town, the network will automatically switch to another circuit. With this redundancy, the service to the Town has been increased to 10 gigs.

Respectfully Submitted,  
Peter Langmore, Manager  
Kim Bergland, Member  
June Masee, Member

February 18, 2026

## **RECREATION DEPARTMENT FISCAL YEAR 2025**

### **Halloween, October 26, 2024**

Our Halloween event was held October 26 and included Trunk-or-Treat vehicles, candy, popcorn, drinks, toy treats and drinks. We all admired the creativity of the Trunk-or-Treat vehicle decorations.

### **Memorial Day Picnic, May 26, 2025**

Blandford's Memorial Day Picnic was held May 26. This picnic has been growing year-to-year and we are lucky to host the Gateway Band on alternate years. We welcomed over 100 residents and are thankful for the many volunteer hands on board grilling hot dogs, hamburgers, sausages along with many different summer salads and desserts. Face tattoos was a Favorite and lemonade, iced tea and water were available. One of our Recreation members set up a Treasure Hunt for the kids. And of course, Mr. Whippy Soft Swirl was there for a special treat after lunch. Another feather of this event is that residents bring their 'tag sale' items and line up on Watson Park Road and create an impromptu Tag Sale for picnic goers to enjoy. We look forward to 2026!

### **Pancake Breakfast, December 6, 2025**

Recreation teamed up with the Blandford Volunteer Fire Department to offer a fun Hot Chocolate Bar for the kiddos only to realize the adults were into this as well. Starbucks coffee is always donated by the Starbucks store near the Mass Pike.

Joann Martin, Chair; Charles Benson and Justin LaFrance

## TOWN CLERK

The Town Clerk is responsible for town records, birth, death and marriage. Most important is the Town Census, or Street List.

The Street List tracks the town's population annually, which is necessary for school census and voter registration. If the records are as accurate and as complete as residents can provide information, that helps grant applications for special purpose funding.

If registered voters fail to complete their Street List, they are removed from the active voter listing and there is a protocol in place to re-establish the voter as active.

The clerk is also responsible for public records requests.

Posted office hours are 4 to 6 p.m. on Monday but please call the office and your all will be returned promptly.

We are always available by appointment.

### **Town Statistics**

13 recorded births

2 recorded deaths

No marriages

There are 912 residents in 626 households, of the households there are 84 vacant.

There are 885 registered voters of which 136 are inactive.

All dogs must have rabies protection; the office receives copies from the veterinarians. All dogs must be licensed by May 1 and this can be done online through the clerk's web page.

Doris L. Jemiolo

Mary Kronholm, Assistant Town Clerk

TREASURER  
Town Debt

Permanent Bond for Phase I Granted by Rural Development \$1,183,803 @4.375%  
For 38 years issued 06/08/2004  
Interest paid in FY25 \$24,532.51 Principal paid in FY25 \$31,153.00  
Remaining Balance \$529,590.00

Permanent Bond for Phase II Granted by Rural Development \$1,288,697 @4.5%  
For 39 years issued 12/16/2004  
Interest paid in FY25 \$41,372.86 Principal paid in FY25 \$29,325.14  
Remaining Balance \$890,072.64

Permanent Bond for Phase III Granted by Rural Development \$1,600,623 @4.375%  
For 38 years issued 08/28/2006  
Interest paid in FY25 \$42,765.69 Principal paid in FY25 \$27,338.31  
Remaining Balance \$950,909.16

Permanent Bond for Phase IV Granted by Rural Development \$882,000 @4.125%  
For 39 years issued 06/12/2007  
Interest paid in FY25 \$20,523.03 Principal paid in FY25 \$22,616.00  
Remaining Balance \$474,912.00

Short term Broadband Bond Anticipation Note issued for \$1,090,000.00

Respectfully,  
Sara Hunter, CMMT  
Treasurer/Collector

## **WATER DPARTMENT ANNUAL REPORT 2026**

### **Completed Projects:**

We replaced chemical feed pumps at the water treatment facility. Four out of seven propane heaters were repaired. Both pumps at the North Street booster station were rebuilt. The pressure relief valve was replaced. The water flow at the North Street booster station was reduced from 25–30,000 gpd to 5–10,000 gpd after multiple leaks were identified and repaired.

### **Operational Improvements:**

We expanded procedures for cleaning filters at the treatment facility to improve performance and extend filter life. Increased frequency and number of hydrants flushed to help reduce DBPs. A complete directional flush of all hydrants will be performed by June 30, 2026, with assistance from the Fire Department, per Department of Environmental Protection requirements. Also, two additional annual flushes will continue, focusing on dead-end areas.

### **Regulatory Compliance:**

The Water Department has passed disinfection byproducts requirements for the past two quarters. The system returned to compliance for the LRAA (locational running annual average) as of December 2025. The first-quarter DBP results for 2026 are pending at the time of this report.

The Water Department has been manually adjusting the flow pace of the treatment facility to reduce water waste until the Supervisory Control and Data Acquisition project is completed. Once upgraded, the SCADA system will automatically pace the treatment plant based on water consumption. This will help reduce chemical usage and extend the life of GAC and sand filters. The treatment plant was originally designed to run at a single pace.

### **Annual Water Production Totals:**

- 2023 – Raw Water: 62.5 MG, Finished Water: 31.3 MG (Million Gallons)
- 2024 – Raw Water: 44.1 MG, Finished Water: 33.9 MG
- 2025 – Raw Water: 31.7 MG, Finished Water: 31.5 MG

### **Funding & Projects:**

The former Water Superintendent Gordon Avery secured \$1,462,000 to complete consent-order projects under MassDEP oversight.

Bradley Curry, Chair; Peter Thayer, member  
Steve Grondon, Interim Superintendent

## **ZONING BOARD OF APPEALS**

The Zoning Board of Appeals fielded numerous inquiries from residents and potential owners regarding property usages allowed by Blandford's Zoning Bylaws.

There were no applications or hearings for Special Permits or Zoning Variances.

Respectfully submitted,

Kim Bergland  
Chair, Zoning Board of Appeals

# ADDENDA

## **Local Election Results 2025**

There were 156 ballots cast in the June 14, 2025 town election.

David Hopson had 132 votes as Assessor.

Jennifer Girard had 127 votes for Board of Health.

Charles Benson had 131 votes for Library Trustee.

June Masee, incumbent, took the Municipal Light Board seat with 75 votes to James Gaeta's 73; Jacqueline Coury received 117 votes over Jeffrey Allen, who had resigned in April but it was too late to remove his name from the ballot; he received 32 votes and Petr Thayer received 131 votes for Water Commissioner.

The Fence Viewer and Field Driver positions all received tie votes resulting in a failure to elect.



**Certified Minutes  
Special Town Meeting  
September 22, 2025  
Town of Blandford  
Hampden County, s.s.**

On Monday, September 22, 2025, at 6 p.m., inhabitants of Blandford qualified to vote in elections and town affairs met at the Blandford Town Hall, One Russell Stage Road, Blandford, Massachusetts on Monday and acted on the following matters:

**ARTICLE 1:** To see if the Town will vote to authorize the Select Board to take such action as it deems necessary and appropriate to express the Town's opposition to the petition submitted by NSTAR Electric Company, d/b/a Eversource to expand the existing electrical substation located at 79 North Blandford Road, and further recommend that the Select Board devote available time and resources to opposing said project before regulatory authorities as determined by the Select Board to be in the best interest of the town; or take any action relative thereto.

**ARTICLE 1:** appropriately motioned and seconded; secret ballots cast 140 yes, 25 no. **Article 1** passed.

**ARTICLE 2:** To see if the Town will vote to authorize the Select Board to take such action as it deems necessary and appropriate to express the Town's opposition to the development of additional commercial-scale solar energy projects within the Town, and further recommend that the Select Board consider such actions as may be possible to restrict such future projects, and devote available time and resources to opposing said projects before regulatory authorities, as determined by the Select Board to be in the best interest of the Town; or take any action relative thereto.

**ARTICLE 2:** appropriately motioned and seconded; secret ballots cast 134 yes, 26 no. **Article 2** passed

**ARTICLE 3:** To see if the Town will vote to authorize the Select Board to take such action as it deems necessary and appropriate to express the Town's opposition to the siting and development of commercial Battery Energy Storage Systems within the Town, and further recommend that the Select Board take appropriate steps to oppose and restrict such facilities, and devote available time and resources to opposing said projects before regulatory authorities, as determined by the Select Board to be in the best interest of the Town; or take any action relative thereto.

**ARTICLE 3:** appropriately motioned and seconded; secret ballots cast 142 yes, 22 no. **Article 3** passed.

**ARTICLE 4:** To see if the Town will vote to raise and appropriate or transfer from available funds the sum of \$200,000.00, to be expended under the direction of the Select Board, to fund engineering services, expert witnesses, and legal services, and incidental and related expenses, to address pending and future commercial solar applications, commercial Battery Energy Storage System applications, and the petition submitted to the Energy Facilities Siting Board by NSTAR Electric Company d/b/a Eversource to expand the existing electrical substation located at 79 North Blandford Road; or take any action relative there to.

**Article 4:** amended to read:

**ARTICLE 4:** To see if the Town will vote to raise and appropriate the sum of \$200,000.00, to be expended under the direction of the Select Board within fiscal year 2026, , to fund engineering services, expert witnesses, and legal services, and incidental and related expenses, to address pending and future commercial solar applications, commercial Battery Energy Storage System applications, and the petition submitted to the Energy Facilities Siting Board by NSTAR Electric Company d/b/a Eversource to expand the existing electrical substation located at 79 North Blandford Road; or take any action relative there to.

**Article 4** appropriately motioned and seconded as amended; secret ballots cast 138 yes, 18 no.

**ARTICLE 5:** To see if the Town will vote to raise and appropriate the sum of \$68,250 to fund the full-time Assistant Treasurer/Collector position; or take any other action relative thereto. Finance committee without quorum unable to recommend; motion appropriately made and seconded; **Article 5** passed as declared by moderator.

**ARTICLE 6:** To see if the town will vote to transfer from Water Department Revenue the sum of \$24,000 to fund the full-time Water Superintendent position for the remainder of FY26 or take any other action relative thereto. **Article 6:** appropriately motioned and seconded, article passed; as declared by moderator.

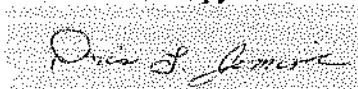
**ARTICLE 7:** To see if the town will vote to transfer from 65-450-5420-000000-0000(water department expenses) the sum of \$92. to pay for previous fiscal year KP Law, P.C. invoice that was not included in the encumbrances; or take any other action relative thereto.

**Article 7** appropriately motioned and seconded; passed unanimously as declared by moderator.

**ARTICLE 8** To see if the Town will vote to transfer from the building stabilization fund the sum of \$20,000 to be expended under the direction of the Select Board, to fund necessary upgrades to the Town Hall gymnasium in order to better accommodate large public meetings, including but not limited to upgrading audio visual equipment, including any incidental and related expenses to address baps in audio visual equipment; or take any action relative there to.

**Article 8** passed unanimously as declared by moderator.

This is a True Copy Attest:



Doris Jemiolo  
Town Clerk



**Certified Minutes Special Town Meeting  
November 17, 2025  
Commonwealth of Massachusetts  
County of Hampden, ss.  
Town of Blandford**

Inhabitants of Blandford qualified to vote in elections and town affairs met at the Blandford Town Hall, One Russell Stage Road, Blandford Massachusetts on Monday November 17, 2025, at 7 P.M., then and thereto to act on the following matters:

**ARTICLE 1:** To see if the Town will vote to amend the Town's Zoning By-laws by inserting a new Section 18 as follows; or take any action relative thereto:

***Section 18.*** Temporary Moratorium on the Construction of Large-Scale Ground Mounted Solar Photovoltaic Installations and Battery Energy Storage Systems.

**A. Authority and Purpose**

The Town of Blandford currently has three approved large-scale ground mounted solar photovoltaic installations, commonly referred to as "solar farms", completed or under construction, two that are in the permitting process and three more that have expressed interest in pursuing permitting within the Town. Additionally, the Town is also aware of a large-scale battery energy storage system that intends to seek permitting this year. Pursuant to the Zoning By-laws, large scale ground mounted solar photovoltaic installations and battery energy storage systems, are allowed pursuant to site plan review and special permit in the Agricultural zoning district, which includes approximately 90% of the Town's land area. The Town is experiencing unexpectedly high demand for large scale solar facility special permits, and together with the emphasis being placed on the development of solar energy to reduce dependence on fossil fuels, and the potential availability of large areas of open space in the Town, it is anticipated that applications to site large scale solar facilities and battery energy storage systems in the Town will continue unabated. The unexpected high demand has demonstrated the potential for rapidly changing the face of the Town, thereby raising unanticipated legal, planning, and economic issues and creating an urgent need to regulate the use.

At the time of adoption of the Town's current Zoning By-Laws, the scope and scale of potential energy development in Blandford was limited by existing grid constraints, particularly the capacity of Eversource's transmission and distribution infrastructure. The Town has since learned of and is responding to a substantial substation expansion project proposed and permitted by Eversource within the Town, intended to increase the system hosting capacity of the regional grid. According to utility studies associated with the Plainfield-Blandford Group Study, the existing transmission and distribution facilities in the area do not have sufficient hosting capacity to accommodate the volume of Distributed Generation (DG), including solar and battery projects, currently proposed or anticipated. The substation and related distribution upgrades are explicitly

designed to resolve these limitations, thereby enabling a significant increase in the number and scale of new interconnections.

The expanded capacity of the upgraded substation is expected to make Blandford more attractive to commercial energy developers seeking special permits or other local approvals. The Town's current zoning framework does not adequately account for the likely volume, intensity, and cumulative impacts of such development, nor does it reflect the modern technological, environmental, and land use implications of utility-scale battery energy storage systems or co-located renewable installations.

Notably, when the Town's zoning provisions were last adopted or amended, the regional infrastructure improvements now underway were entirely unknown and not reasonably foreseeable. As a result, large portions of the Town, including approximately 90% of its land area, remain potentially open to commercial-scale energy development under outdated and insufficiently protective standards.

The Town seeks to avoid unintended consequences of unchecked or poorly regulated commercial solar and battery energy storage development while it undertakes a deliberate and comprehensive planning process. This process will include public input, expert consultation, and the development of zoning amendments that ensure any future energy development is consistent with the Town's land use goals, environmental protections, rural character, infrastructure limitations, public safety, and State regulations.

Therefore, this temporary moratorium is necessary, reasonable, and narrowly tailored to serve the public interest while the Town updates its bylaws to responsibly manage a rapidly evolving energy landscape. The moratorium will not apply to residential roof mounted or small or medium ground mounted solar installations.

Together with the increase in demand, the law concerning the ability of municipalities to regulate solar energy facilities and battery energy storage systems through its zoning bylaws has evolved substantially by way of recent court decisions and Attorney General review of proposed amendments to those bylaws. The Town's recent attempts to address the impact of large-scale solar facilities and battery energy storage systems through amendments to its Zoning By-laws have been only partially successful, due in large part to the changes in the law. The Town needs time to study the impact of this evolution on its current regulation of these facilities and adjust that regulation as necessary to ensure that it conforms to legal requirements while adequately addressing the impact of large-scale solar facilities and larger battery energy storage systems on the Town and its planning goals. Imposition of a temporary moratorium on the Construction of Large-Scale Ground Mounted Solar Photovoltaic Installations and Battery Energy Storage Systems will allow sufficient time to assess these issues and amend the Zoning By-laws to conform to legal requirements and address the impact of these facilities on the Town's environmental resources and its planning goals.

#### **B. Temporary Moratorium.**

For the reasons set forth above and notwithstanding any other provision of the Zoning By-laws to the contrary, the Town hereby adopts a temporary moratorium on the use of land or structures for Large Scale Ground Mounted Solar Photovoltaic Installations and Battery Energy Storage Systems. The moratorium shall be in effect through **May 31st, 2026**, or the date on which the Town adopts amendments to the Zoning By-laws concerning Large Scale Ground Mounted Solar Photovoltaic Installations and Battery Energy Storage Systems, whichever occurs earlier. During the moratorium period, the Town shall undertake a planning process to study, review, analyze

and address what revisions to the Zoning By-laws relative to Large Scale Ground Mounted Solar Photovoltaic Installations and Battery Energy Storage Systems are needed or desirable to allow for and regulate such use consistent with applicable law while protecting the Town's environmental resources and furthering its planning goals.

*Requires Two Thirds Vote*

**ARTICLE 1: Appropriately motioned and seconded; voice vote; passed with a two-thirds majority vote as declared by Moderator Hopson**

**ARTICLE 2:** To see if the Town will vote to transfer from Water account 65-450-5420-000000-0000 the sum of \$3,517.09 to pay for previous fiscal year Berkshire Springs invoices that were not included in the encumbrances; or take any other action relative thereto.

*Requires nine-tenths vote.* **ARTICLE 2: appropriately motioned and seconded; passed unanimously**

**ARTICLE 3:** To see if the Town will vote to transfer from Highway account 01-422-5240-000003-0000 the sum of \$342.55 to pay for previous fiscal year Palmer Paving Corporation invoice that was not included in the encumbrances; or take any other action relative thereto.

*Requires nine-tenths vote.*

**ARTICLE 3: appropriately motioned and seconded; passed unanimously**

**ARTICLE 4:** To see if the Town will vote to transfer from Highway account 01-422-5700-000000-0000 the sum of \$93.00 to pay for previous fiscal year reimbursement invoice to Ryan Keach that was not included in the encumbrances; or take any other action relative thereto.

*Requires nine-tenths vote.* **ARTICLE 4: appropriately motioned and seconded; passed unanimously**

**ARTICLE 5:** To see if the Town will vote to transfer from available funds the total sum of \$320.43 to pay for previous fiscal year bills to Verizon that were not included in the encumbrances; or take any other action relative thereto.

*Requires nine-tenths vote.*

**ARTICLE 5: Amended to read:**

To see if the Town will vote to transfer from New Town Hall Utilities the total sum of \$320.43 to pay for previous fiscal year bills to Verizon and \$32.60 for previous fiscal year bill to Eversource that were not included in the encumbrances; or take any other action relative thereto.

**ARTICLE 5: appropriately motioned and seconded; passed unanimously**

**ARTICLE 6:** To see if the Town will vote to transfer the sum of \$14,750.00 from the Reserve Fund to the Highway Department Expense Account for the purpose of paying extraordinary or unforeseen expenditures for necessary repairs to the Highway Department bathroom, including incidental and related costs and expenses; or take any other action relative thereto.

*Requires Simple Majority.* **ARTICLE 6: appropriately motioned and seconded; passed unanimously**

**THIS IS A TRUE COPY ATTEST**



**Doris L. Jemiolo,  
Blandford Town Clerk**



**Certified Minutes  
Special Town Meeting  
December 9, 2025  
Commonwealth of Massachusetts  
County of Hampden, ss.  
Town of Blandford**

In the name of the Commonwealth of Massachusetts, the inhabitants of Blandford qualified to vote in elections and town affairs met at the Blandford Town Hall, One Russell Stage Road, Blandford, Massachusetts on Tuesday December 9, 2025, at 7 P.M., then and thereto to act on the following matters:

**ARTICLE 1:** To see if the Town will vote to approve the Porter Memorial Library Expansion and Renovation Project, and further to appropriate the sum of \$7,546,161.00 to fund the renovation, alteration, improvement, preservation, and expansion of the Porter Memorial Library located at 87 Main Street, including but not limited to design, engineering, site preparation, and construction costs, and any incidental and related costs; and that to meet this appropriation to authorize the Treasurer, with the approval of the Select Board, to borrow said amount under and pursuant to the provisions of G.L. c. 44, Section 7 or any other enabling authority, and to issue any bonds or notes therefor; and further, to authorize the Select Board and/or the Library Trustees to apply for and accept any forms of financial assistance that may be available to the Town on account of this project, including Massachusetts Board of Library Commissioners grant funds, which amounts received shall reduce the amount to be borrowed by a like amount; and further, to authorize the Select Board and/or the Library Trustees to enter into all agreements and execute any and all documents as may necessary on behalf of the Town, including contracts in excess of three years, to effectuate the Project; or take any action relative thereto.  
*Requires a two-thirds vote: Hear Finance Committee Recommendation*

**ARTICLE 1: Passed unanimously with standing vote as called by Moderator Hopson.**

**A TRUE COPY ATTEST:**

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Mary Kronholm, Assistant Town Clerk



**Certified Minutes Special Town Meeting  
December 19, 2025  
Commonwealth of Massachusetts  
County of Hampden, ss.  
Town of Blandford**

In the name of the Commonwealth of Massachusetts the inhabitants of Blandford qualified to vote in elections and town affairs met at the Blandford Town Hall, One Russell Stage Road, Blandford, Massachusetts on Friday, December 19, 2025, at 7 P.M., then and thereto to act on the following matters:

**ARTICLE 1:** To see if the Town will vote to transfer from Certified Free Cash the sum of \$370,000.00 to reduce the amount raised and appropriated for the Town's Fiscal Year 2026 Annual Budget as approved by a vote taken under Article 5 of the June 2, 2025 Annual Town Meeting, for the purpose of reducing the Fiscal Year 2026 tax levy, or take any other action relative thereto.

**ARTICLE 1:** appropriately motioned and seconded; passed unanimously as called by Moderator David Hopson

**A TRUE COPY ATTEST**

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Doris L. Jemiolo, Blandford Town Clerk